The Jade Cauldron

Book I: Of Common Tonics, Uncommon Elixirs, and the Proper Use of an Hourglass
Compiled by Scholar-Physician Wei Zhen of the Academy of Apothecaries
A field copy prepared for physicians, travelers, and curious householders of Tianxia

Chapter I: The Rule of One Vessel

Every recipe has exactly one solvent and between one and three distinct solutes. The solvent is the fluid carrier: water, oil, wine, vinegar, tree sap, rice wash, broth, or another liquid. Solutes are the active materials: leaves, roots, powders, mineral dust, monster parts, or burned ash. An ingredient may be crushed, dissolved, or suspended; it need not disappear completely. One batch fills one standard potion vial and produces one consumable. One listed portion of each solute is needed.

Chapter II: Implements and the Six Operations

- Grinding:
    - Crush a dried leaf, shell, or root with a mortar and pestle to free its virtue.
- Mixing:
    - Fold the prepared solutes into the selected solvent, stirring steadily.
- Boiling:
    - Heat a vessel until a quiet simmer carries flavor, color, or magic into the fluid.
- Burning:
    - Reduce a prepared material to ash, then add the cool ash as a suspended solute.
- Dissolving:
    - Stir a powder until dispersed; sediment is acceptable if shaken before use.
- Distillation:
    - Heat the mixture and lead its vapor through a cool tube into a receiving vial.

An hourglass measures one turn as ten minutes.

Chapter III: Common Remedies and Roadside Draughts

Entry I — Potion of Healing

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Spring water Solutes: Rogue's Morsel

Preparation: Grind the herb to a red-green paste; dissolve it in warm water and strain through linen for one turn.

Apothecary's observation: Fresh specimens stain the pestle; dried ones are less fragrant but equally useful. When drunk, wounds visibly heal and stop bleeding

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Entry II — Antidote

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Clean water Solutes: Mugwort

Preparation: Grind the leaves finely, boil for one turn, and decant the clear green liquid.

Apothecary's observation: This antidote does not mend damage already dealt by poison. Alleviate poison effects

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Entry III — Draught of Animal Speech

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Rice wine Solutes: Acorn Truffle

Preparation: Slice the truffle, grind it, and mix it into the wine. Let it settle for one turn.

Apothecary's observation: Do not expect a donkey to become clever merely because you can. For 1 hour, you can understand and verbally communicate with beasts and understand their complaints.

Entry IV — Feather-Fall Cordial

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Spring water Solutes: Autumn Crocus

Preparation: Grind the petals, steep for one turn, and catch the pale liquid before it darkens.

Apothecary's observation: A poor remedy for a fall already completed.

Entry V — Glorious Vaulting Tonic

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Tree sap Solutes: Wispweed

Preparation: Warm the sap and dissolve crushed Wispweed into it for one turn.

Apothecary's observation: A leap made without considering where one lands remains a foolish leap.

Entry VI — Clear-Eye Tea

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Hot water Solutes: Chrysanthemum blossoms

Preparation: Steep the blossoms for one turn; stir and strain before sealing.

Apothecary's observation: A popular examination-day tea, though no decoction can replace study. When drunk, clearer vision lasts for 1 hour.

Entry VII — Ginger-Warmth Draught

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Rice wash Solutes: Ginger root

Preparation: Crush the root and simmer in rice wash for one turn.

Apothecary's observation: Common among ferrymen who work before sunrise. Travellers often drink this to alleviate exhaustion imposed solely by ordinary cold exposure

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Entry VIII — Bitter-Reed Stomach Tonic

Grade: Common | Hourglass: 1 turn

Solvent: Boiled water Solutes: Lotus seed

Preparation: Grind the dry seed and boil for one turn, then stir the settled powder back in.

Apothecary's observation: Travellers often drink this to alleviate food poisoning

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Chapter IV: Skilled Draughts for the Practiced Hand

Entry IX — Potion of Greater Healing

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Spring water Solutes: Balsam, Rogue's Morsel

Preparation: Burn a pinch of dried Balsam to ash, grind the herb, then mix and simmer for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: A little ash in the vial is expected.

Entry X — Potion of Mind Reading

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Clear water Solutes: Mergrass, Weavemoss

Preparation: Grind both plants, mix, and distill the fragrant vapor into a clean vial over two turns.

Apothecary's observation: What is overheard cannot always be unheard.

Entry XI — Potion of Speed

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Rice wine Solutes: Hyena Ear, Haste Spores

Preparation: Dry and grind both materials, dissolve in wine, and heat gently for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: A dangerous favorite of duelists who expect quick victories.

Entry XII — Elixir of Fire Resistance

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Sesame oil Solutes: Dragon Egg Mushroom, Fire Amber

Preparation: Burn the dried mushroom to ash, powder the amber, and mix into warm oil for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: Shake thoroughly before drinking

Entry XIII — Elixir of Barkskin

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Tree sap Solutes: Wood Bark, Chasm Creeper

Preparation: Grind the bark, shred the creeper, and dissolve both in warmed sap for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: It leaves the skin textured like polished timber. Makes it harder to damage.

Entry XIV — Night-Watch Elixir

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Spring water Solutes: Crystalline Lens, Nightlight

Preparation: Powder the lens, steep Nightlight, then distill the mixture for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: Especially valued by guards assigned to unlit watchtowers.

Entry XV — Jade-Marrow Restorative

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Rice wine Solutes: Ginseng root, Goji berries

Preparation: Grind the ginseng, crush the berries, and simmer in wine for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: Among itinerant physicians, this is the medicine offered when rest is impossible. Improve one's constitution temporarily for one hour

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Entry XVI — Still-Pond Breathing Tea

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Hot water Solutes: Lotus root, Bamboo leaf

Preparation: Grind lotus root, add bamboo leaf, and boil for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: River divers prize it; it does not allow breathing underwater. Drinkers can hold their breath for 15 minutes within one hour.

Entry XVII — Incense of the Steady Hand

Grade: Skilled | Hourglass: 2 turns

Solvent: Clear water Solutes: Sandalwood ash, Chrysanthemum blossoms

Preparation: Burn a prepared pinch of sandalwood to ash, steep blossoms, and mix for two turns.

Apothecary's observation: Some call it an artisan's tonic; others insist it is a cheat.

Chapter V: Masterwork Preparations and Rare Virtues

Entry XVIII — Potion of Superior Healing

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Yellow Musk Creeper Petals, Balsam, Rogue's Morsel

Preparation: Grind the petals and herb, burn the Balsam to ash, then boil and filter for three turns.

Apothecary's observation: Its amber surface is flecked with soft yellow light.

Entry XIX — Potion of Supreme Healing

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Distilled water

Solutes: Ki-Rin Hair, Balsam, Yellow Musk Creeper Petals

Preparation: Burn the Balsam, grind the petals, suspend the hair in water, and distill for three turns.

Apothecary's observation: The use of a sacred creature's hair makes the provenance of every vial a moral concern.

Entry XX — Potion of Flying

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Eagle Feather, Wispweed, Autumn Crocus

Preparation: Burn a feather to ash, grind the flowers and weed, then distill for three turns.

Apothecary's observation: A physician should first ask whether the patient fears eights.

Entry XXI — Potion of Invisibility

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Clear water

Solutes: Imp Patagium, Mergrass, Shadowroot Sac

Preparation: Grind the membrane and sea grass, dilute a trace of the sac in water, then distill for three turns.

Apothecary's observation: A dishonest servant is not made honest by becoming unseen.

Entry XXII — Elixir of Heroism

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Pegasus Feather, Ginseng root, Wispweed

Preparation: Burn the feather to ash, grind the root and weed, and warm in wine for three turns.

Apothecary's observation: Its taste is austere, like rain on old stone.

Entry XXIII — Golden Bell Tonic

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Tree sap

Solutes: Reishi mushroom, Ginseng root, Jade powder

Preparation: Grind the mushroom and root, suspend jade powder in warmed sap, and stir for three turns.

Apothecary's observation: A guarded recipe of body-cultivators, not an excuse to stand before a charging ox. Drinker seemingly shrugs off bludgeoning attacks

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Entry XXIV — Five-Elements Harmony Decoction

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Spring water

Solutes: Lotus seed, Dragon Egg Mushroom, Viridian Crystal

Preparation: Grind the seed and crystal, burn the mushroom to ash, then boil for three turns.

Apothecary's observation: The practitioner selects one virtue; the draught never grants all five.

Entry XXV — Moon-Gate Dream Elixir

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Rice wine

Solutes: Night Orchid, Lotus blossom, Mergrass

Preparation: Grind the lotus, mix with orchid and Mergrass, and distill for three turns under a shaded hood.

Apothecary's observation: It reveals no objective truth; the dreamer must still interpret memory.

Entry XXVI — Breath of the Mountain Sage

Grade: Masterwork | Hourglass: 3 turns

Solvent: Pine sap

Solutes: Reishi mushroom, Bamboo leaf, Wispweed

Preparation: Grind the reishi, shred the leaf, and slowly dissolve into warm pine sap over three turns.

Apothecary's observation: Traditionally carried by traveling calligraphers and Qi practitioners. Students also misuse this to concentrate on their studies.

Appendix I: Cautions and the Judgment of a Physician

The commonest failure in alchemy is not an explosion, but the assumption that a remedy answers a question it was never asked. A potion that mends wounds will not mend a broken promise. A potion that reveals thoughts will not prove their truth. A potion that defeats poison will not forgive the hand that administered it. If the vessel smells of rancid fat, if sediment has become furred with mold, or if an inexperienced assistant claims that the mixture has begun speaking, do not serve it. Clean the cauldron, ask a second opinion, and begin again. I have known men to spend more upon a single elixir than their village spends on winter grain. I do not forbid such purchases. I merely suggest that one consider whether the intended miracle might be achieved more cheaply with water, rice, a dry blanket, or kindness.

— Wei Zhen, Scholar-Physician